

*“History, which is a simple whore, has no decisive moments but is a proliferation of instants, brief interludes that vie with one another in monstrosity.”* (Bolaño)

In the staleness full of smoke of a coffee shop and hookah lounge, my pockets are about full of nothing as I pat on each of their characteristic seams, the entropy has nowadays left alone the memory of what I even had, if it wasn't but foolish advertisement and junk. The initiative to pay for something was also left somewhere but the pants I was wearing.

I did the pocket search dance with a small heart attack while the barista pulled my daily six shots of their medium roast in a sugarless Americano. The wallet, nowhere to be found, was probably dreaming about storing the money of an outlaw's bounty (hunted in the wild west fashion) or at least some genre of epic that includes being filled with treasures. All while laying in my unwashed pants from the night before.

In my head, there must exist some unobserved God who likes to play out small inconveniences to hold back the withdrawal symptoms from the lack of Greek adventures that the modern days present. Something like sliding his hand into one unassuming subject's pocket and flying their keys back into their car, then he goes back into his office and plans the next strike while listening to Take Five. So I damned that God, for there wasn't a wallet anywhere a wallet could be.

In cases like this, the primal survival instincts developed by our ancestors have abstracted fight or flight to the much less convenient frown or fright, but that special morning the thick cream of espresso smelled much like my deceased grandmother's home. So I did the next best thing and zoned out while staring uncomfortably at a college freshman blonde, a surrounding presence over the counter that simulated the likes of a caffeine wired Mia Wallace, who dressed like a mix of every Quentin Tarantino character,

her face so innocent I couldn't help imagining Tarantino might have accidentally written a saint and it escaped his storyboard.

Hyperventilating, I told her to give me a moment to look if I had left the wallet on the outside table I had been using to read my worn down copy of Counterexamples in Topology. The scheme through little tiffany seats yielded no results, people were synchronously rummaging through their bottoms smoking on their outside seats, helping me find my wallet like I had prayed everybody itched in the same spot, at the same time. Truly, I wanted to get away to escape the endless ticking of remembrance. The speed and density of the traffic outside cannot outpace being hunted down by a memory.

Recently, I went to Hermosillo Sonora, and I cried, I had missed the scenic beauty of the roads that I grew up traveling. The closeness to the beach is a Midas touch of greenery for a season a year. The fertility of the ground gives the impression of a lost paradise.

The sociopolitical ambience unlike the rest of the state raises the question whether you had traveled back to the north. The Catholic church in the center of the city plaza stands like a monolith of faith, for some the inheritance of years of Spanish violence, some others call it the opium of the people, but for many it is a symbol of good will: somewhere to know death doesn't come alone, and somewhere to know that dead isn't forgotten. The same church was spray painted with the venus sign, and the same plaza held purple signs protesting the names of different women who had disappeared (vanished in thin air isn't a good descriptor here, because the wet winds of the city aren't thin whatsoever, and the lack of causation would divert from the common denominator tying several of these disappearances together). The names of four women in a roughhoused-with pamphlet caught my immediate attention for the rest of the day.

For some reason, I remembered my birthday, I turned 18 on a Thursday. I was finally legally allowed to go drinking, and I had received my national voting card only a few weeks earlier. The tour de force in logistics of a teenager extends only up to the immediate excitement of novelty. Back in the day my friend group consisted of four girls and me, and it

is a common thing in Mexico to offer bar and club discounts to women during Thursday nights, it is excused as a promotion to bring in more people on a slow day. So we went to drink and play karaoke, I was drunk but I can vaguely recall Luis Miguel's "Ahora te puedes marchar" and "Cielito lindo" in the repertoire, my friends went for less traditional options like Miranda, and Shakira. The night was dim lit by a full moon and we had to call a sober friend to pick us up. You remember the people you love when you sense tragedy, as a mannerism of protection, maybe the attempt was to go back to a time they could have been more safe in my memories.

I was 5 or 6 years young, blindly experiencing dad's job crisis which landed us on relying on my maternal grandma's support in Mexico. Living in her home where, once, the usual "instant coffee and assorted cookies" themed gossip session between my mom and my grandma would be interrupted by the knocks of a weeping man.

During the time of my family's economical defeat, I used to set up stands to sell my own toys, usually varied ones that I would source from fast food restaurants, digging the ground, collecting my older sister's unused things. One of the best selling toys were cat figurines which would earn me a humble five pesos each. There are no lions or tigers in Mexico and that is probably the reason why children liked it so much. Perhaps, due to the poor business model I described, I ended up finding out that stealing was a much better idea to not feel poor, which we were. Thankfully, my grandma and my mother taught me that there is no deal in riches if I were to follow the path of the 'bad guys'. To a child, a bad guy could be anything. In my imagination, a bad guy could be possibly a mad scientist who intended to transform everybody into mutants, a really nasty political organization that tried to take over the world, the neighbors that my dad kept complaining about for blasting "loud and inappropriate music", a pond of quicksand, really anything.

Anyways, I kept dreaming about selling cats.

The first time I saw a big cat, it was only its skull, in Guanajuato, at a haunted castle showing the torture devices of the inquisition, an ancient predator stolen from the deep jungles and put in a glass cage that would allow me to take a picture with my mouth wide open, mimicking the pose it was installed in for the foreseeable two or three land preservation acts.

The thought of putting one's head in the molars of the long dead beast was still scarier than the aesthetical beauty of dying for one's own religion through a man-made torture device: the length of the canines passing through the soft tissue wouldn't give me time to see the memories of my life lead up to an undeserved death, to hum in a 5/4 time signature: I wouldn't have had to count the total amount of milligrams of nicotine I had through my life (a rough estimation gives 1.395 grams a month which is enough to poison an average adult lion), ask the mom in my memories if she still loved who I had become, remember to ask the mischief God to feed my pets for me in my absence and to smite the routing number of the Raising Canes manager that rejected my job application. That's how powerful the jaw of a four legged carnivore really is, it could make you miss the rough sketch of things you can't do in your next life.

I wouldn't have time to realize I truly was not the apex predator.

July of 2025, Jesús Antonio would joke about claiming the life insurance from Margarita, his wife. Some day of the same month, a trip to the beach would result deadly for her and her three children: Meredith, Medeline, and Carla. 11 years old twins and a 9 year old, respectively. All shot by their stepfather (N+ Univision). For a kid, a bad guy shouldn't be their stepfather who is associated with the narcos, a bad guy should be the grade system at school, the tumbleweeds in cartoons, and witches who can come up with complex schemes to steal the graces from fantastic beings. A kid should be playing with the pogs in the bags of chips (the way junk food would sell in the early 2000s), and learning about geography with a government assigned book larger than their backpack. Their bodies should be found laying in the sunlight of a comfortable home, alive, dreading the daily news and the gossip channels that their parents watch on live TV; instead of being found

underground by the many collectives of forensic searching in the state, which have found more than 1200 corpses altogether (Feminismo por la Paz).

You see, I am a mathematician. It is one of those things that a Mexican child wouldn't expect to have become unless they were born to the Bourgeois. The geography atlas we study, the one that is larger than our backpacks in elementary school. It never pointed out to graphs of the levels of literacy, nor did it point out regions with formal studies. So as far as my awareness on the butterfly effect that tames adults into business casual khaki pants, I am a product of a major chain of coincidences all interconnected by a worn out red string with knits similar to the ones of the leather sandals my grandma used to sell.

Ever since the development of fancier math that has led us to computing, humans have leveraged a part of their knowledge into classifying problems of the class of language, and solving these languages. One of these problems is called the  $P = NP$  problem (Clay Mathematics Institute), which has many fancy introductions like explaining how a machine that generates languages can be more-or-less complex than another machine that generates other many languages (More formally, does  $L \leq_p L'$  by a computable function with a machine  $M$ ,  $f_M : \Sigma^* \rightarrow \Sigma^*$ ). But the essence of the problem comes down to the question: Are the problems we can compute and solve the same as the problems that we can verify? Or more so, is the magical machine that can always take the right decision equally as powerful as the one machine that has to go through the process of solving for those right decisions?

I remember my mother holding me to lock me in the room where I had all of my toys spread through the floor. Historically, it is a bad idea to hold a kid back without explaining the reasoning for it. Most children, even those who disappear, are curious by nature and will instead fight back against a command with unsupervised eavesdropping of adult conversations. This is a tale as old as time. So in the face of being bored by the new series of McDonald's toys, I rummaged through a conversation I didn't have the brains to

understand whatsoever, I only knew that it smelled like instant coffee, and a man was crying for his life and for his family: his son was dead. This was probably one of my first attempts at ever so slightly pondering about mortality. In my personal defense, back then I was still in the middle of reciting the primary colors to my teachers in English and making an inhumane attempt to not pee in long car rides.

In one of the many Sonoran highway adventures I had as a child, I had to come to terms with my developing consciousness: the roads are badly rated, long, and I would have possibly drunk enough Horchata to use the urinal for a laughable amount of time for a child. Thankfully, back then that was the only of my worries, I had to believe in ghost stories instead of being haunted by the journalist and media worker violence that had led to their corpses being posted up in the bridges that connected the roads. Nor did I have to worry about the master scams, about the political parties that would manipulate the forthcoming approach to money that the population would either take or silently protest: violence. (Animal Político & MCCI)

The man in my grandma's home wanted to talk to somebody about getting blackmailed by the cartel that had threatened to kill his daughter and wife if he continued protesting the death of his son, who had been killed after a miscommunication in a club, where he had flirted with the girlfriend of a cartel member, leading up to his abduction and disappearance.

Based on hearsay and research, the father's investigation of his son's disappearance had him face to face with some members who explicitly claimed having fed him to the lions. The intact canines of ancient cats came to my head; I thought about torture devices from the inquisition, and I scanned through my current surroundings looking at feeble men acting like gangsters. Back when Porfirio Diaz dictatorship was fighting revolutionary movements, the clothes stripped from the dead army men were sent back with the quote "ahi te van las hojas, mandame mas tamales" (there goes your leaves, send me more tamales; nodding at the fact that tamales come wrapped in leaves) (Kohout), there must have been some level of correspondence in winning a fight with well-armed men and letting their family rejoice in

the faint smell of their sweat and blood, on having something from your loved ones back after a miserable subscription to a fight they may or may not care about.

He, whose name I still don't know, was probably a man like many more: going out on a Tuesday night to get a few beers with his friends, owing his mom a phone call every once in a while, never having a real reason to think about lions. But unlike me, his wallet wasn't waiting with ambition in a pile of trashy clothes; his wallet wasn't found anywhere.

Formally, the problem of solvability vs. verifiability asks not for the labor of computing and thinking hard, but the mercy of a single witness: a certificate that can check for such a truth quick enough. In which case, does it even matter? Isn't a lifetime to verify the problem of a disappearance same as a second to verify in the eyes of a grieving parent? This is the obscene efficiency of loss, it strips away all of the mystique of language and the entropy of detail: our realm is the one where problems go to die as a continuous forthcoming of verifications. Suddenly, the value of a jawbone, the trash in the pocket, holes in the chest, every receipt of existence is mumbled up in a unity of measure of identity that verifies the nature of the crime that was committed is the one of the crime suspected. The presence of the absence is only left to close family of the victims while the object as a witness of the crime lies as a symptom of the state's culture to let the details, the meat of the action itself sink. Once the crime has passed, all that is left is a depersonalization of the victim, the numerical value that they have in a long file of search lists that the Madres Buscadoras or any other collective has to carry out as a consequence.

Investigations don't occur regularly in Saturdays and Sundays in Mexico, that is, the city where a disappearance occurs will only open the case file for a missing person on a Friday, but the research process associated with the disappearance will only extend to a lesser potential until after a two day break. The verifiability problem rises again and the authorities will ask to submit a claim of disappearance once 48 hours have passed after the person was noticed as missing.

It takes an average of one day and nineteen continuous hours to drive from Nogales, Sonora, to Guatemala city in Guatemala, allegedly, it took Kafka an overnight sitting to write the majority of the Trial, two days can feel like hell on earth for a relative that has lost the track of your steps walking the earth. One day you can go clubbing on a Thursday and wake up in a stranger place, two days ahead of any possible rescue, as claimed by the dad of Esmeralda Castillo Rincón, José Luis Castillo, whose daughter disappeared on her way to school on May 19, 2009, in Ciudad Juárez, with her name being deleted from the missing person lists after a survey done by the federal government in 2023: tying to a broader pattern of the exclusion of missing people names (El Financiero), (Reporte Indigo).

Outside of my own head, people were still asking if I needed any help to find my things, they were asking whether the wallet was brown or black, I honestly didn't know, I was pale in the midday heat of Arizona. The severance of the many things missing from my memory had a chokehold on the technical ability to slur out two or three polite words to the folk that surrounded me like they were prepared to call a paramedic. The words from the modern world and time were coming to me like passages from an underworld, the Church I visited and the idea of a God plagued for a second my otherwise atheistically-lived life, the true colors of the things that I have lived only being a more lucky reflection of what could have been. There is something sickening in the thought that I had escaped the fate, and the one of my friends, and the one of my family, without ever thanking the hands that lend me such a destiny. An illness of sorts fills my stomach still every time I think about the people that had been buried against their will in a heat similar to the one that I was standing. I didn't think that death could be approached with deterministic intent as to leaving one the option to say yes or no, at least most of the times, but even the consciousness of where and how to die might have approached better the shape of the memories that were hunting me down. A deep resentment, and an alarming desperation for all of those things in the future that ideology, and pinning down the problem to a board illustrating the numbers wouldn't ever do. Solving instead of verifying.



For a second there I missed a man who I never knew like he was my own son, the dream of raising my future children in the same places as the ones I grew melted by the day and that one sunny afternoon was the evaporation point. I felt the rage of a country where you can be the child of your future murderer without ever growing to understand the deep sociopolitical connections that led to it being that way.

I snapped out of my confusion. The barista noticed the nauseated look in my eyes, realizing that all along I was scared of forgetting a wallet, so she offered the coffee on the house since I was a common customer. I went back to tip her \$10.82, and I invited her to watch a movie at my place, a deadly idea in Mexico.

## **Bibliography**

- [1] R. Bolaño, 2666. Editorial Anagrama, 2004.
- [2] N+ Univision, “Revelan las últimas horas de las hermanitas presuntamente asesinadas por su padrastro en Sonora.” [Online]. Available: <https://univision.com/>
- [3] Feminismo por la Paz, “Madres y familias buscadoras en México.” [Online]. Available: <https://feminismoporlapaz.eus/archivo/madres-familias-buscadoras-mexico/>
- [4] Clay Mathematics Institute, “P vs NP.” [Online]. Available: <https://www.claymath.org/millennium/p-vs-np/>
- [5] Animal Político & MCCI, “La Estafa Maestra del gobierno federal.” 2026.
- [6] M. D. Kohout, “Orozco, Pascual, Jr.” [Online]. Available: <https://www.tshaonline.org/handbook/entries/orozco-pascual-jr>
- [7] El Financiero, “Papá de Esmeralda Castillo acusa que la borraron del registro de personas desaparecidas.” [Online]. Available: <https://elfinanciero.com.mx/>
- [8] Reporte Indigo, “¿Por qué las mujeres desaparecen los jueves? La teoría del papá de Esmeralda Castillo.” [Online]. Available: <https://reporteindigo.com.mx/>

## MLA research log.

The MLA research log for the sources cited will not be too contrasting with each other, there are many ideas which do not oppose each other, either because the sources are factual or the articles do not give much opinionizing (whether it is personal or not). Sadly, I do not have the technical skill to incorporate Roberto's 2666 without outright quoting him as I did in the start. But still include him in this conversation between sources because I believe the thesis of his book is akin to the one of my paper, only presented much more sensibly with his literature resources, and infra-realist narrative devices.

### 1. Bolaño, Roberto. *2666*. Editorial Anagrama, 2004

- Unlike most other sources, Roberto's writing rejects writing from a purely realistic or journalistic perspective, while he does implement element and cases from real life.
- Similar to my writing, his thesis ultimately thinks of evil and the human cost of the crimes in "Santa Teresa" as a structural pathology of society instead of a monstrous sprawl. The horrid sentiment is that it all is systemic and, most of the times, long lost.
- The reason why I added the case of Esmeralda was specifically because of the parallelism with the cases of feminicidios that Roberto reports in "Santa Teresa".

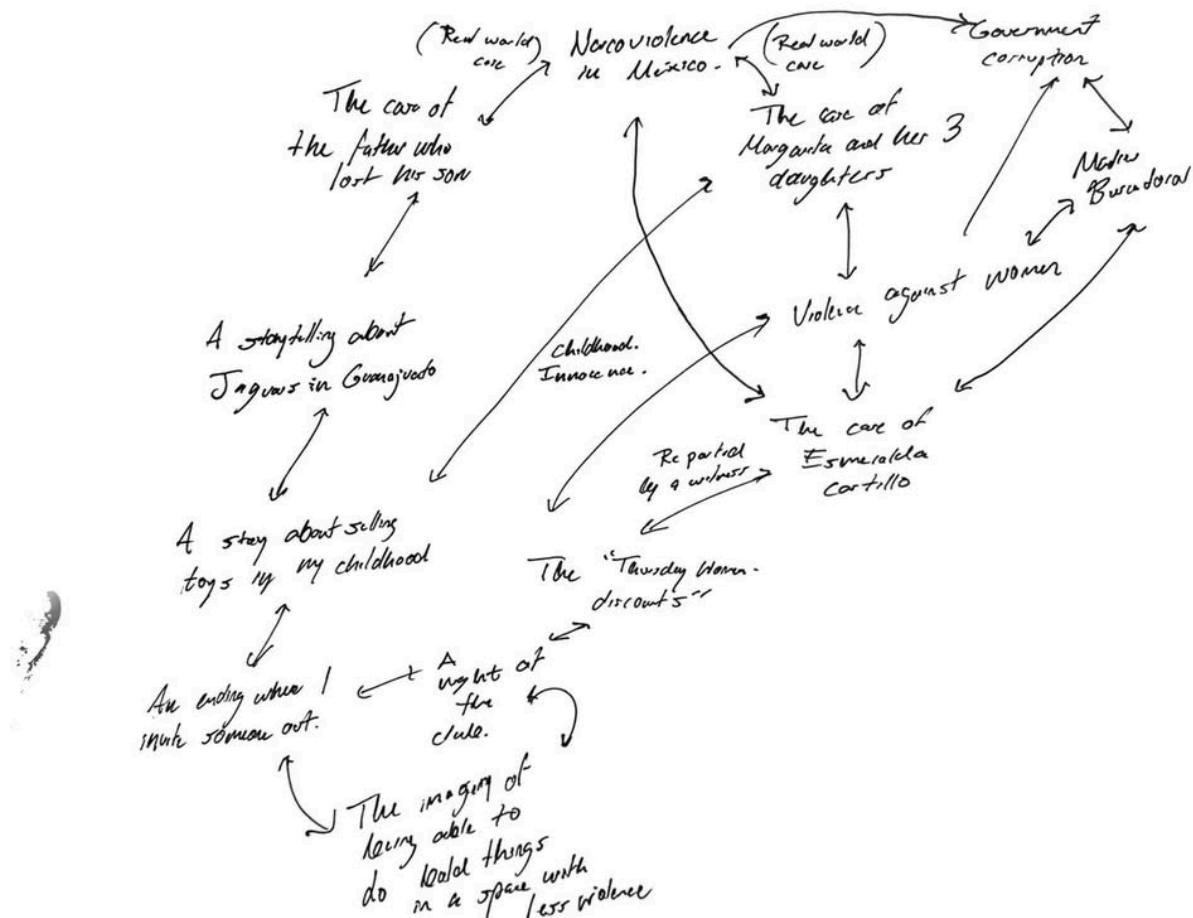
### 2. Clay Mathematics Institute. "P Vs Np." 2026, <https://www.claymath.org/millennium/p-vs-np/>

- One of the parts of the braided essay that completely resists a realistic, grounded analysis. It covers a problem about computability, so it is a misfit used to make and report over a metaphor.
- One of the feelings that I wanted to evoke in this paper was the one of something missing, that there is a piece of the structural relations and the politics and Mexico that doesn't suffice to comprehend the interlink between the stories that are mentioned. This problem achieves it in two ways: the problem is literally a problem about verifiability, it is asking whether being able to notice that something is right or wrong is equivalent to solving it. And the problem is, ironically, unsolved.

- There is not much parallelism. There is nothing this tells narratively and it doesn't advance me in the essay nor any of the cases I reported on, at least not directly.
3. Feminismo por la Paz. "Madres Y Familias Buscadoras En México." <https://feminismoporlapaz.eus/archivo/madres-familias-buscadoras-mexico/>
    - This doesn't differ much from all other documents. Matter of fact, it is short.
    - The driving point of mentioning the madres buscadoras ties closely with the fact that the government is corrupted by the Narco movements. People have to resort to the use of their own resources, and community led teams to do forensics.
    - There is no sheer parallelism because the mention of this isn't explicit (I don't do the effort to explain things which are apparent).
  4. Reporte Indigo. "¿por Qué Las Mujeres Desaparecen Los Jueves? La Teoría Del Papá De Esmeralda Castillo." 18 Mar. 2025, <https://reporteindigo.com.mx/>
    - This could be considered popular media, and the trend of talking about it has been slowly pushed down by the Government, though it is a widely known phenomenon across Latin America, where "Ladies nights" or "2x1 drink discounts for women" are posted in clubs exclusively on Thursdays, since some clubs are a hangout spot or owned by organized crime, it makes sense that this is more of a logistics move where cases of missing women are correlated with times where there is less investigators active in a region.
    - This also goes closely with the fact that the government isn't proactively attacking the major strategies that target women, and younger demographics.
    - I embedded this with the personal story about my birthday. The only time I've ever gone drinking on a Thursday ever. I feel a tremendous guilt learning about this and thinking about how much of these strategies I could have ignored or not known about while hanging out with a group of girls.
  5. (Univision is widely known for its journalism, but also taken as a popular source, with writing that has obscured specific topics) N+ Univision. "Revelan Las Últimas Horas De Las Hermanitas Presuntamente Asesinadas Por Su Padrastro En Sonora." 8 July 2025, <https://univision.com/>

- This story stands out. There is not an argument offered by the article but there is an extremely worrying pattern of violence occurring as to subject three people of the same family to witness their most loved ones die. This is a sickening case, and it happened near one of the places I used to visit often as a kid, which I don't mention explicitly, but if analyzed geographically within the story, can give validity to the point: all of this violence is occurring closer than it may appear on text. This separates it from other stories, some which I heard from hearsay.
- I think this is an advance in the personal story of "when I was a kid". Most of the elements that I presented were rather innocent in nature during those stories, all to evoke that there is something gruesome in what is being done to the general population, even those who haven't had the time in their life to experience and learn the systematic problems that lead to crime. Once again, makes it even more sickening to think that innocent children were murdered by someone they were closed to, in a trip to the beach.
- The parallelism with the other stories in this context is that the stepdad was actually first charged for "Narcomenudeo" (small scale drug dealing).

## The ladder of abstraction:



I think that part of the research that would have moved further up in the ladder of abstraction would have been exactly citing books like *The Savage Detectives*, or *2666* which more abstractly (or adding fictitious elements) happen to show through the lens of literature a more crude version of the violence in the country without ever losing sight of the aesthetic elements that describe such gruesome violence. One of the reasons this level of abstraction didn't happen in my essay is due to technical skills, or more so, the time-to-content sacrifice that, in a braided structure, would have lost a lot of the details in dense descriptions, quotations, or unflattering paraphrasing of the author in question.

My hyperdictions in question are grounded to the thematic, if I would have scaled up, or down, in any other case. I ran the risk of running with a lot more explicit content or I would have found myself lingering around more storylines than I sought to have in order to maintain the attention of the reader in question. One of the things which I would have wanted to add in the hyperdictions is "forensic details", and with it, all of which

encompasses it. I have a thesis on the human's brain exposure to crude violence that would have been a complement to the driving point of the braided essay. However, I find it disrespectful to utilize shock content in order to argument my own point without first having made enough excavation of the details, and possibly asking witnesses. The brutality and monstrosity of the crimes has a lot of depictions which make a much more diverse specification of the psyche that the murderers have, but is it worth putting attention to the murderer in on its own without pointing the finger at the systematic failures that had led to these moments? One has to go with another. Which risks of density in a shorter style of writing.

In the case of my writing, the audience can be anybody. I believe that violence is a worldwide problem, but only the details on how it happens signal the regional and sociopolitical identities that reflect on a violent crime. In which case, it is expected that anybody is able to tell from the writing that

a) There is a problem. b) The problem is in Mexico c) The problem is of violence d) The problem of violence extends against innocent civilians, mostly children, and women, followed by unwilling, unknowing people.

Some of the aspects of the writing can be strictly understood by Mexicans, or Latin Americans. Up to where my understanding goes, things like leather sandals, pogs in the bags of chips, they aren't as trendy (or were in their specified time) in the US as they were in the southern regions of America, which suffer of the same problem.

About the projection of my own person in my writing goes. I intended for the route of speaking through a personal voice, and instead of reflecting violence through the paradigm of sheer journalism, I liked better the option of a slow gradient from an ironic, almost satirical tone, to a serious and desperate tone. A call for help which I expect to be noticeable by the end. One of my main goals insofar as my character in writing, is that it is a simple person. The details given are the ones of a man who could be any of my peers, someone who forgets their wallet, studies their math, grew up abroad. The sacrifice of a deeply emotional voice is intended, because I don't find it viable to make it seem like at the

moment of occurrence of many of the things that I know about violence, I wasn't a child. It would be unfair for the reader to learn that a child had the captivating capacity to empathize with a world which he did not understand at all, and was protected from by his parents at the start of his life. The only part of my voice which escapes this common pattern is at the last moment where I make a mention of having escaped the hands of fate. A comment which is true, when I was a teenager I associated by coincidence with many people who could have gotten me in the wrong steps very quickly.

